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— MILLIONPODCASTS RESEARCH · INDUSTRY INTELLIGENCE REPORT

The State of Video Podcasting, 2026.

An evidence-based portrait of approx. 34,000 active English-language video podcasts, who makes them, who listens, what actually moves the needle on growth, and why the ecosystem behaves nothing like the rest of the creator economy.

Scope: English-language only · Method: ~34K video shows, active in the last 12 months · Snapshot: 28 April 2026

PODCASTS ANALYZED

34,208

active English-language video podcasts (12-month activity filter)

TOTAL EPISODES PUBLISHED

7.70M

cumulative episodes across the active catalog, an observed count, not a modeled estimate

RUN SPONSORSHIPS

22.9%

monetize via brand partners

MEDIAN MODELED LISTENERS

2,000

modeled median for shows in this catalog, not directly comparable to per-episode download benchmarks

READ THIS FIRST · WHAT THIS REPORT MEASURES

This is a catalog-level scan of approximately 34,000 unique English-language video podcasts active in the last twelve months. Directly observed counts: episodes published, Apple review counts, platform presence (Apple / Spotify / YouTube), publishing cadence, and sponsor activity flags. Modeled estimates: monthly listener counts, audience composition (gender, income tier, generation), and top-decile concentration metrics. Throughout the report, listener counts and audience composition figures are modeled estimates; episode counts, review counts, platform flags, and sponsor flags are directly observed. Where a figure is modeled, the surrounding prose says so explicitly. See the methodology section for full detail.

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Every figure in this report is drawn from a curated set of English-language video podcasts. Country counts and category trends reflect the English-speaking podcast world, not total podcast activity in any given region.

HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

The report moves from the broad shape of the market (Sections 01–06) to the named leaders, team footprint, and deeper cross-cuts (Sections 07–09), and closes with conclusions, methodology, and citation guidance (Sections 10–12). Each figure is numbered by section (for example, Figure 05.2 is the second chart in Section 05) and carries its own sample size where it differs from the full catalog. Throughout, listener counts and audience composition are modeled estimates, while episode counts, review counts, platform flags, and sponsor flags are directly observed; the surrounding prose flags which is which wherever a figure is modeled.

/01 · INDUSTRY OVERVIEW

An ecosystem of extreme inequality.

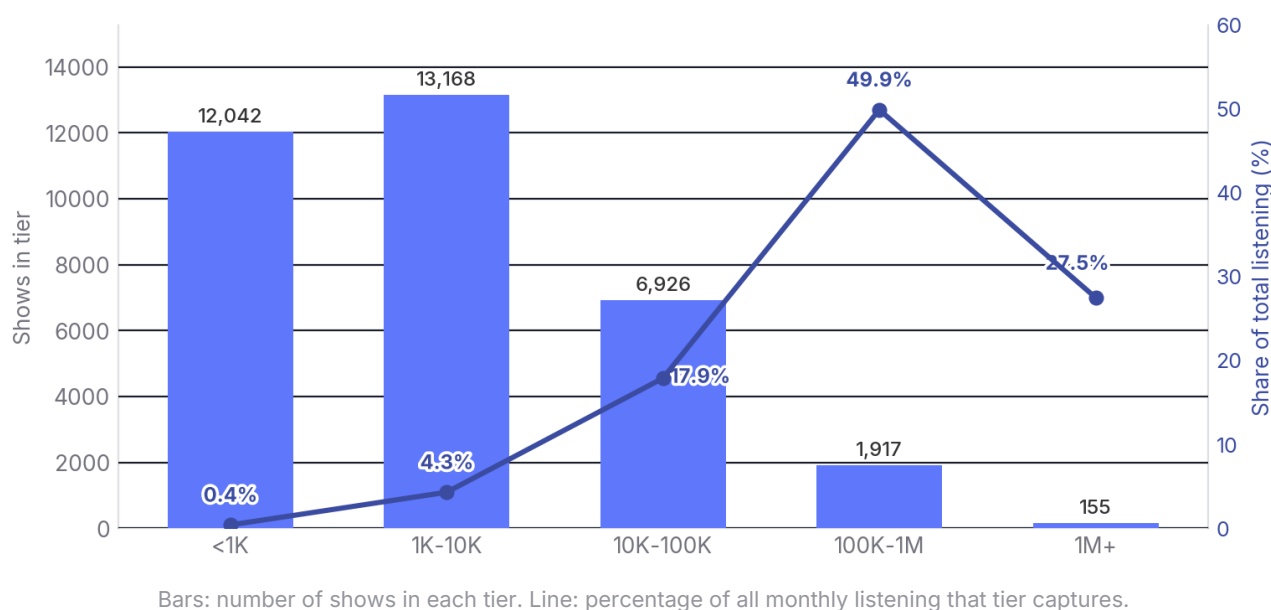
Most podcasts have small, devoted audiences. A tiny minority command the spotlight, the sponsorships, and very nearly all of the monthly listening hours. The middle barely exists.

The video podcast market in 2026 looks healthy on the surface and quietly brutal underneath. This report covers approx. 34,000 active English-language video podcasts (12-month activity filter), one of the largest publicly-analysed podcast intelligence sets available. The dataset spans the full long tail (most shows reach a few thousand listeners) and the very top of the market (a handful of shows clear the multi-million-listener mark). Average ratings sit at **4.8**, and the underlying intelligence data includes modeled audience composition (gender, income tier, generation) and observed sponsor activity wherever it could be detected.

But the moment you look at how listeners are distributed, the picture changes. A typical show in our catalog has a modeled monthly audience of around **2,000 listeners**, respectable as a starting point, but a long way from the headline names. The arithmetic mean, by contrast, is around **32,000**, a sixteen-fold gap that only happens when a small number of shows are doing the heavy lifting for everyone else. Note that this median refers to modeled monthly listeners across the curated active video catalog, and is not directly comparable to per-episode download benchmarks published by hosting platforms (which use different units, different cohorts, and different measurement bases).

85.4% of all monthly listening hours flow to the top 10% of shows. The bottom half of the market accounts for around one percent.

That is not a podcast-specific failure. It is the same power law that governs YouTube channels, Spotify artists, and bestseller lists. What is specific to podcasting is how forgiving the surface looks: even shows with tiny audiences carry strong ratings, because the people who do listen tend to love them.

FIGURE 01.1**Listener reach distribution, show count vs. share of total modeled listening**

TOTAL EPISODES PUBLISHED 7.70M Cumulative episodes ever published across the active catalog. An observed count taken from each podcast's episode total, not a modeled estimate.	TOP-DECILE THRESHOLD 45K Roughly the audience floor a show needs to clear to enter the top 10% of the market.	TOP 1% SHARE OF REACH 41.6% Around 340 podcasts (the top 1% by listenership) hold roughly 42% of all listening across the dataset.
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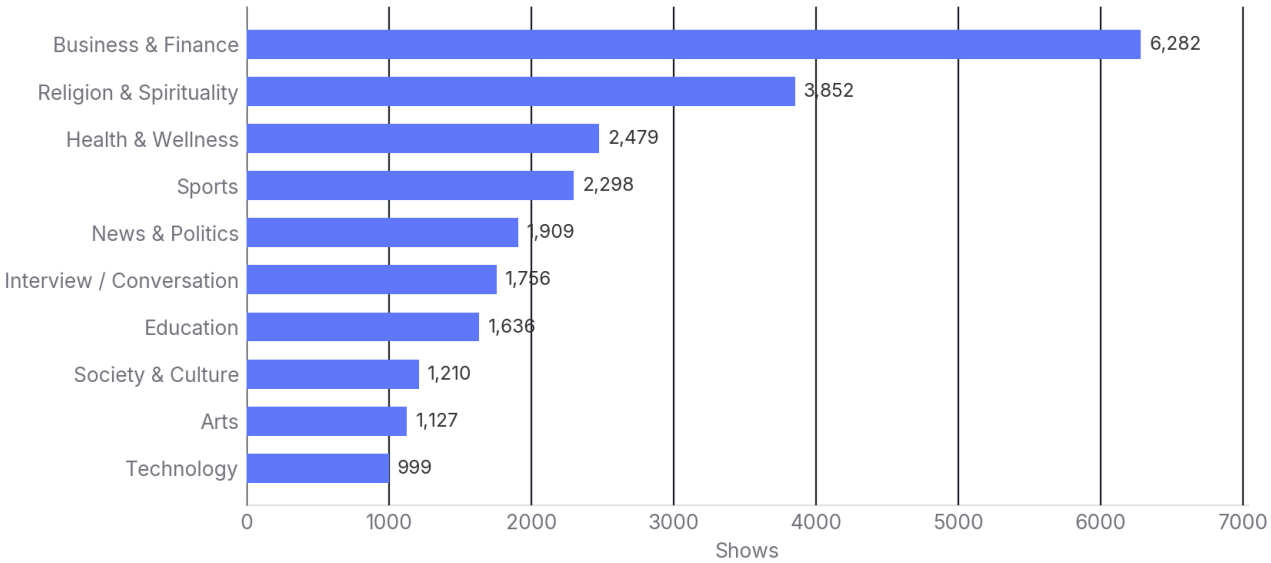
What people make, and what they make a lot of

A clear hierarchy emerges across the long tail. Business & Finance sits at the top with roughly **6,300 shows**, a function of the entrepreneurial coaching and finance-personality boom of the last five years. Religion & Spirituality (~3,900), Health & Wellness (~2,500), Sports (~2,300), and News & Politics (~1,900) round out the top five. Identity, lifestyle, and conversation formats anchor the volume side of the market.

The categories with the highest show count are not necessarily the same ones that produce the highest-audience shows. True Crime is the clearest example. It does not even appear in the top 10 categories by show count, yet it carries two of the ten biggest podcasts by listenership (Crime Junkie and Criminal). This is the power-law signature of the format: a relatively small number of category entries, dominated by a couple of breakout franchises that command enormous audiences each.

FIGURE 01.2

Top 10 categories by show count



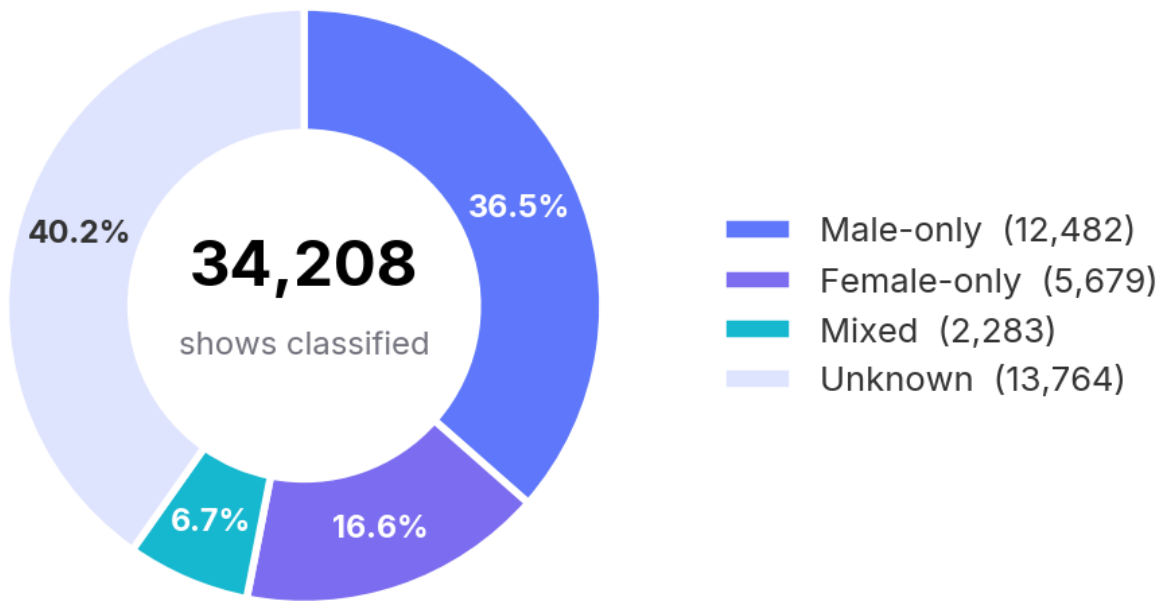
Show counts per category across the active catalog of 34,208 video podcasts.

/02 · AUDIENCE & CREATOR INSIGHTS

Who's behind the microphone.

Counted at the show level, one podcast, one classification, men still produce the majority of English-language video podcasts. But mixed-gender productions punch far above their weight when you look at audience size.

FIGURE 02.1
Host gender at the show level (n = 34,208)



Each podcast is classified once, based on the genders of its hosts. The four buckets sum to 34,208, one classification per show.

Across the full catalog of 34,208 shows, **36.5%** are male-only, **16.6%** are female-only, **6.7%** are mixed-gender productions, and the remaining **40.2%** sit in the unknown bucket where host names or biographies are not recorded. Restricting the calculation to the 20,444 shows where host gender can be identified, the splits become 61.1% male-only, 27.8% female-only, and 11.2% mixed-gender. We report both bases because the 40% unknown share is large enough to materially shift the headline number depending on how it is treated.

A note on terminology: the percentages above describe the host configuration of the show (who is in front of the microphone), not the audience composition. Audience-side gender skew is analysed separately in section /03 and uses different cohort definitions; the two should not be conflated.

Mixed-host shows out-listen single-gender shows by roughly 24% at the median, the strongest format-level signal in the entire creator dataset.

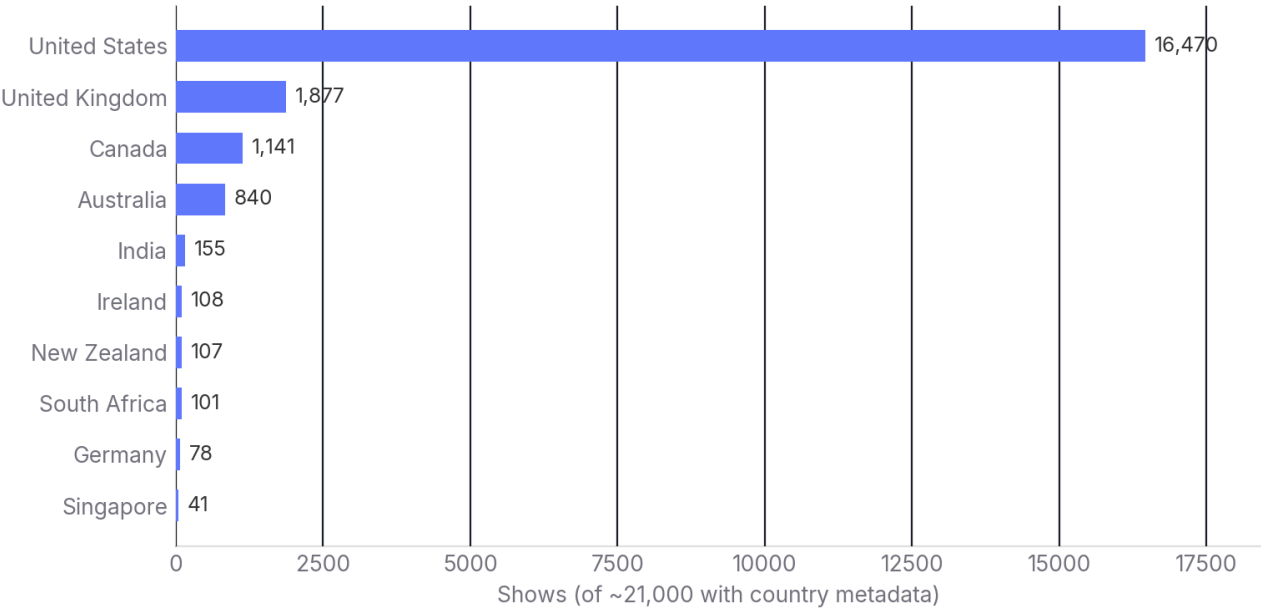
Geography, an English-language map

Country data is available for roughly 21,000 of the 34,000 podcasts in the catalog, about 62%. The remaining ~13,000 shows have no country metadata recorded and are excluded from the geographic breakdown below. Read the percentages that follow as shares of the 21K subset with country data, not shares of the full catalog.

Among the shows where origin can be verified, **79%** are produced in the United States, **9%** in the United Kingdom, **5.5%** in Canada, and **4%** in Australia. Those four English-mother-tongue countries account for roughly 94.5% of all video podcasts whose origin we can verify. (Translated to the full 34K catalog, that equates to roughly 48% confirmed-US, with another 38% of unknown origin.)

This skew is a direct consequence of the analytical scope. The report covers only English-language video podcasts, which is precisely why the United States carries such a disproportionate share. The US share is somewhat lower than typical audio-only podcast datasets (which often run 65–80% US) because video podcasting has gained earlier traction in the UK, Canada, Australia, and India relative to audio-first markets. A low number for Germany, Japan, or Brazil here does not mean those markets produce few podcasts, it means few of their shows are produced in English. The same US dominance carries through into the audience side: the bulk of listener traffic, sponsorship deals, and network signings flows through the same handful of cities. Los Angeles, New York, Austin, and London anchor the visible market.

FIGURE 02.2
Top 10 host countries (by podcast count)



English-language video podcasts · ~21,000 with country metadata of 34,000 total.

/03 · AUDIENCE INTELLIGENCE DEEP DIVE

Who is actually listening.

For every show in this dataset, modeled audience composition tells us not just how many people listen, but who they are, their gender mix, income tier, and generation. This section is the qualitative half of the audience picture.

FEMALE AUDIENCE SHARE

47%

Listener-weighted across the entire catalog. The audience leans slightly male in aggregate (M 52% / F 47%), with around 1% modeled as listeners outside the male/female binary.

MILLENNIAL LISTENING SHARE

49%

Almost half of all podcast listening, weighted by audience size, comes from Millennials. They are the economic centre of gravity of the format.

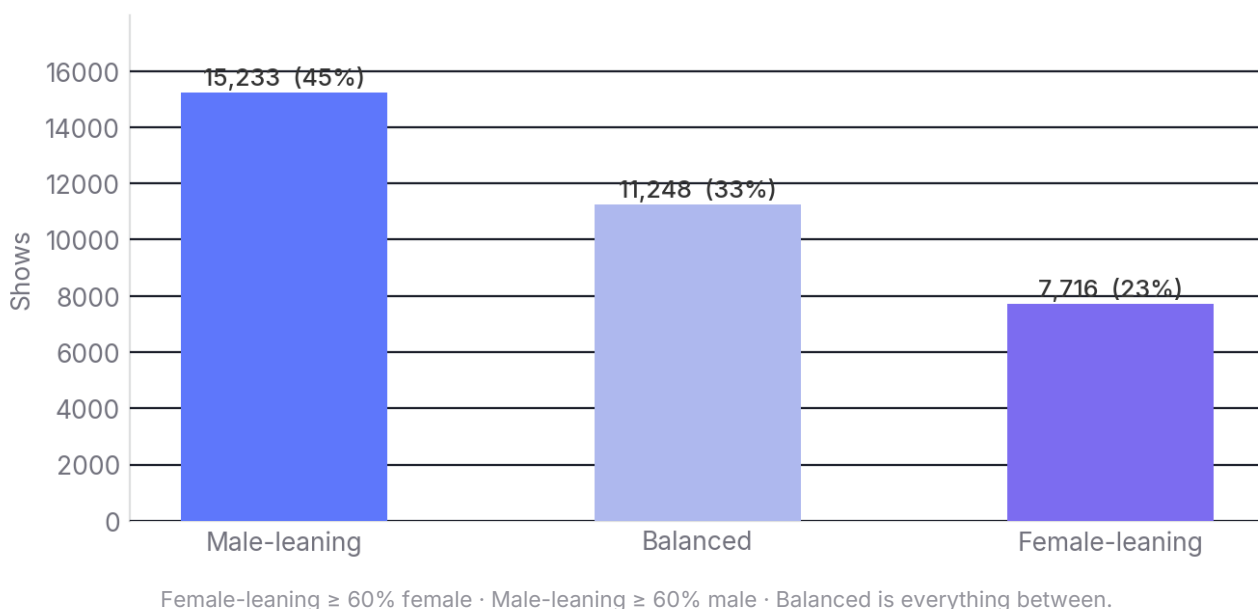
MID-INCOME LISTENER SHARE

59%

Six in ten listeners sit in the medium-income tier. The podcast audience is overwhelmingly mass-market, not premium.

FIGURE 03.1

Audience gender skew, how many shows lean which way (modeled audience)



Most shows lean male, but balanced audiences trail both

Roughly **45%** of podcasts have male-leaning audiences. About **23%** are female-leaning, and **33%** are balanced. The supply skews male, but the gap is smaller than people often assume; nearly a third of all podcasts are roughly gender-balanced in audience composition.

The audience-side picture is more interesting. Female-leaning shows and male-leaning shows reach essentially the same median audience, **2,500 listeners** in each cohort, while balanced-audience shows trail at **1,500**. The data does not say one gender skew outperforms the other. What it does say is that shows with no clear audience lean tend to underperform shows with a clear one, in either direction.

Male-leaning and female-leaning shows reach roughly the same median audience. The shows that struggle most are the ones with no clear demographic centre; balanced audiences are harder to grow because there is no specific community to grow into.

Health & Wellness is a strong example of a female-skewed category, with audiences typically 60–70% female. Sports sits at the opposite end: roughly 70% male on average. The shows that genuinely cross over, Society & Culture, News, mainstream Comedy, tend to land near 50/50 and rely on volume rather than community to grow.

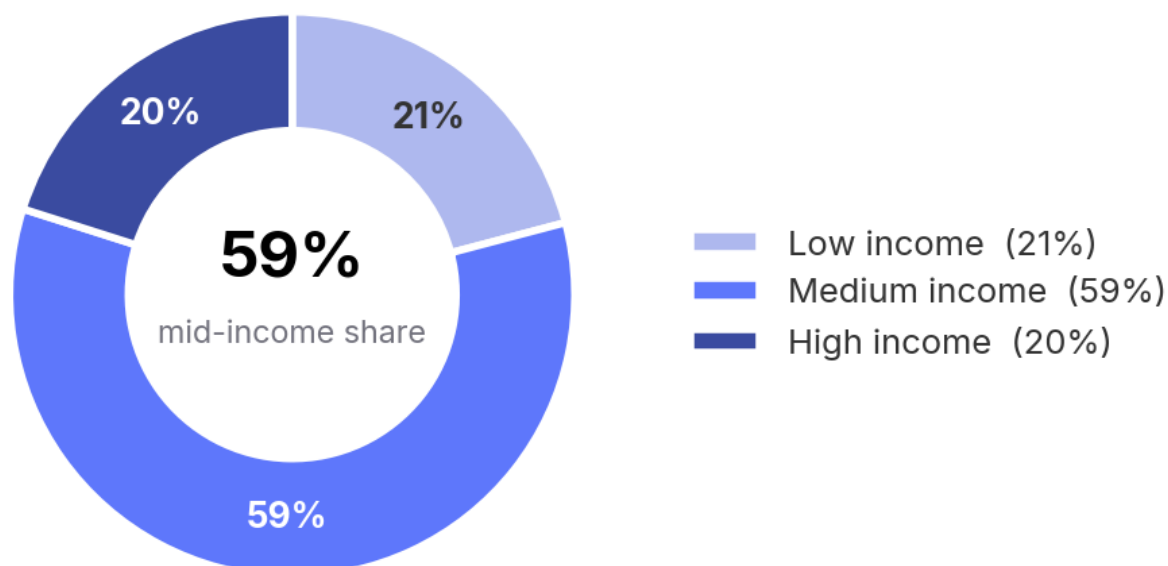
The audience is firmly mid-market

Listener-weighted across the entire active catalog, the income split is **Low 21% • Medium 59% • High 20%**. Six in ten listeners sit in the medium-income tier. The high-income segment is small, and shows that target it have lower median reach, not higher.

High-income-dominant shows post a median of 2,000 listeners; medium-income-dominant shows median 2,000; low-income-dominant shows trail at 700. Most reach lives in the middle of the income distribution because that is where most listeners are. The high-income tier exists but is small.

FIGURE 03.2

Income tier, share of total modeled listening, dataset-wide

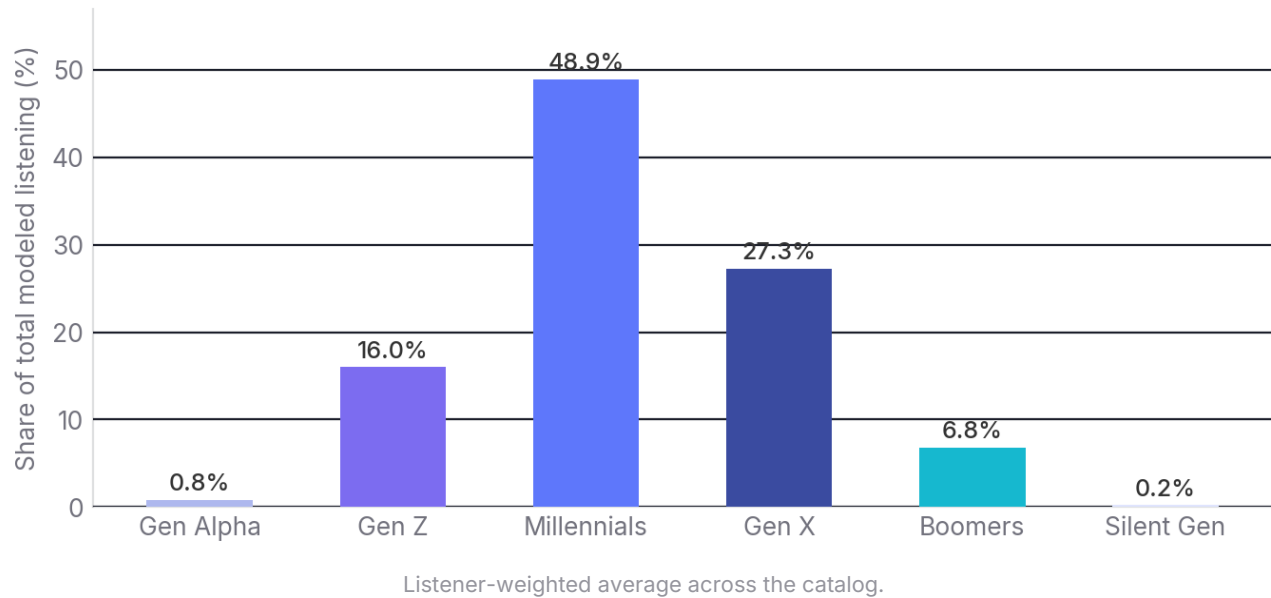


Listener-weighted average across the catalog.

The largest reach is in the middle. The biggest sponsor density is at the top. The two metrics do not line up, which is why a show optimised for one can underperform on the other.

The implication for monetisation: a show built explicitly for affluent listeners will struggle to scale audience, but should command sponsor density. A show built for the mass market will scale audience easily, but sponsor competition for that inventory is fierce.

FIGURE 03.3
Generational mix, share of total modeled listening across all shows



Millennials are the centre of gravity

Roughly half of all podcast listening, weighted by audience size, comes from **Millennials (49%)**. Gen X follows at **27%**, Gen Z at **16%**, and Boomers trail at **7%**. The format is age-coded: it was born in the iPhone era and its core audience grew up with smartphones.

At the show level, 82% of all podcasts come back with Millennials as their dominant listening generation, with Gen X dominating 13% and Gen Z 3%. Read the dominance figures as directional rather than absolute. The underlying classifier tends to default to the modal cohort, so the 82% reflects how often Millennials are slightly ahead on a show, not that 82% of shows are exclusively Millennial. The listener-weighted Millennial share (49%, shown in the card above) is the more reliable headline number because it preserves the underlying mix. (See methodology /14.)

Build for Millennials by default. Build for Gen Z if you are optimising for cultural traction. Build for Gen X or Boomers only if you are chasing a specific subject vertical.

The strategic read: even shows that think they are targeting Gen Z (most comedy, most pop culture) are still being consumed predominantly by Millennials in absolute terms. The Millennial audience is older than the format's self-image suggests, and that has consequences for tone, sponsorship inventory, and content cadence.

Demographic fingerprints by category

Each category has a different audience signature. The table below shows listener-weighted averages of the female share, high-income share, and Millennial share for the ten largest categories in the catalog, alongside the median modeled listeners per show.

Category	Shows	Female %	High-income %	Millennials %	Median listeners
Business & Finance	6,282	46.4%	27.5%	50.8%	2,000
Religion & Spirituality	3,852	55.0%	18.5%	45.5%	2,000
Health & Wellness	2,479	59.1%	20.5%	51.5%	2,000
Sports	2,298	29.7%	19.0%	50.5%	4,000
News & Politics	1,909	44.4%	24.7%	43.3%	4,500
Interview / Conversation	1,756	40.2%	20.0%	48.0%	2,000
Education	1,636	54.6%	18.9%	47.4%	2,000
Society & Culture	1,210	52.0%	18.1%	48.9%	2,500
Arts	1,127	50.4%	22.0%	45.2%	2,000
Technology	999	33.3%	23.2%	51.4%	1,500

Listener-weighted category averages · modeled audience composition · top 10 categories by show count.

The categories sort into clear audience archetypes. Health & Wellness (59% female), Religion & Spirituality (55%), and Education (55%) skew female relative to the catalog, while Sports (30%) and Technology (33%) are the most male. Business & Finance carries the highest-income audience by a clear margin (28% high-income), with News & Politics (25%) and Technology (23%) next; the more general lifestyle categories sit closer to 18–20%. Millennial share is remarkably stable, hovering near half the audience across almost every category, which says the generational centre of gravity is a property of the medium rather than of any single topic.

For a brand, the practical read is to match the category to the demographic it wants rather than chasing raw size. The two highest-median categories, Sports and News & Politics, also happen to be among the most male and the most affluent respectively, so reach and audience profile do not always move together. A buyer optimising for high-income reach would weight Business & Finance and News; one optimising for a female audience would weight Health & Wellness and Education, accepting a smaller median in exchange for a cleaner fit.

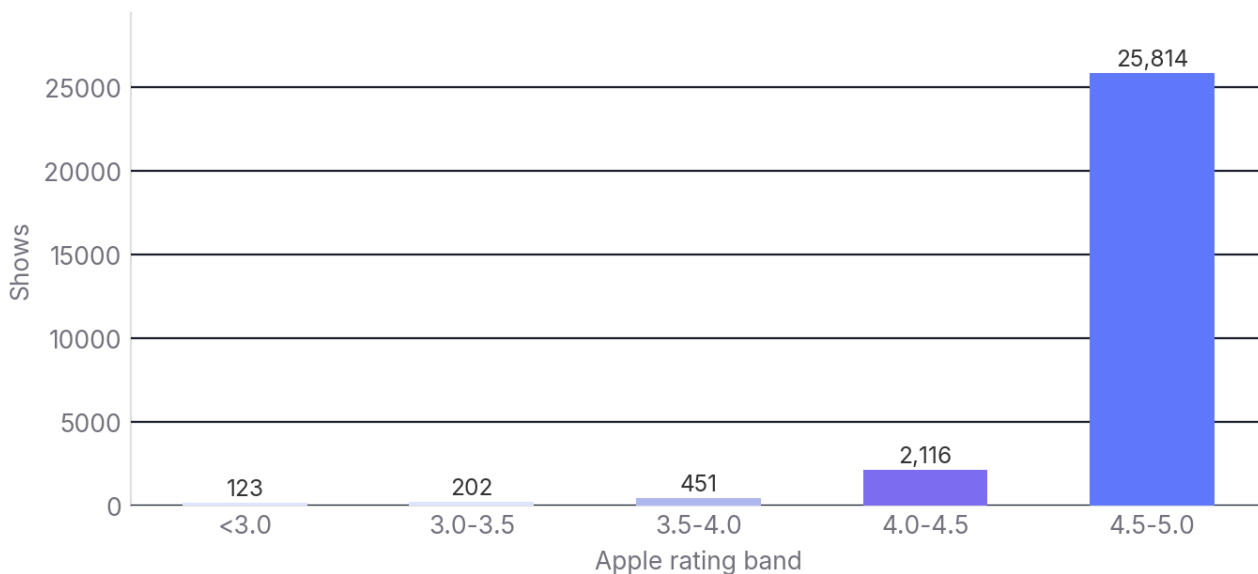
— /04 · ENGAGEMENT ANALYSIS

Reviews are the only honest signal.

Star ratings are nearly meaningless, almost every show is rated above 4.5. What truly tracks listener volume is the count of reviews. Volume of opinion, not quality of opinion, predicts reach.

FIGURE 04.1

Apple rating distribution



Shows with a recorded Apple rating, grouped into half-star bands.

Ratings cluster aggressively at the top. **87%** of shows score between 4.5 and 5.0 stars. Only **1.7%** sit below 4.0. That is not because every podcast is brilliant; it is because the people who bother to leave a rating tend to be the show's biggest fans, and the people who would rate harshly simply stop listening.

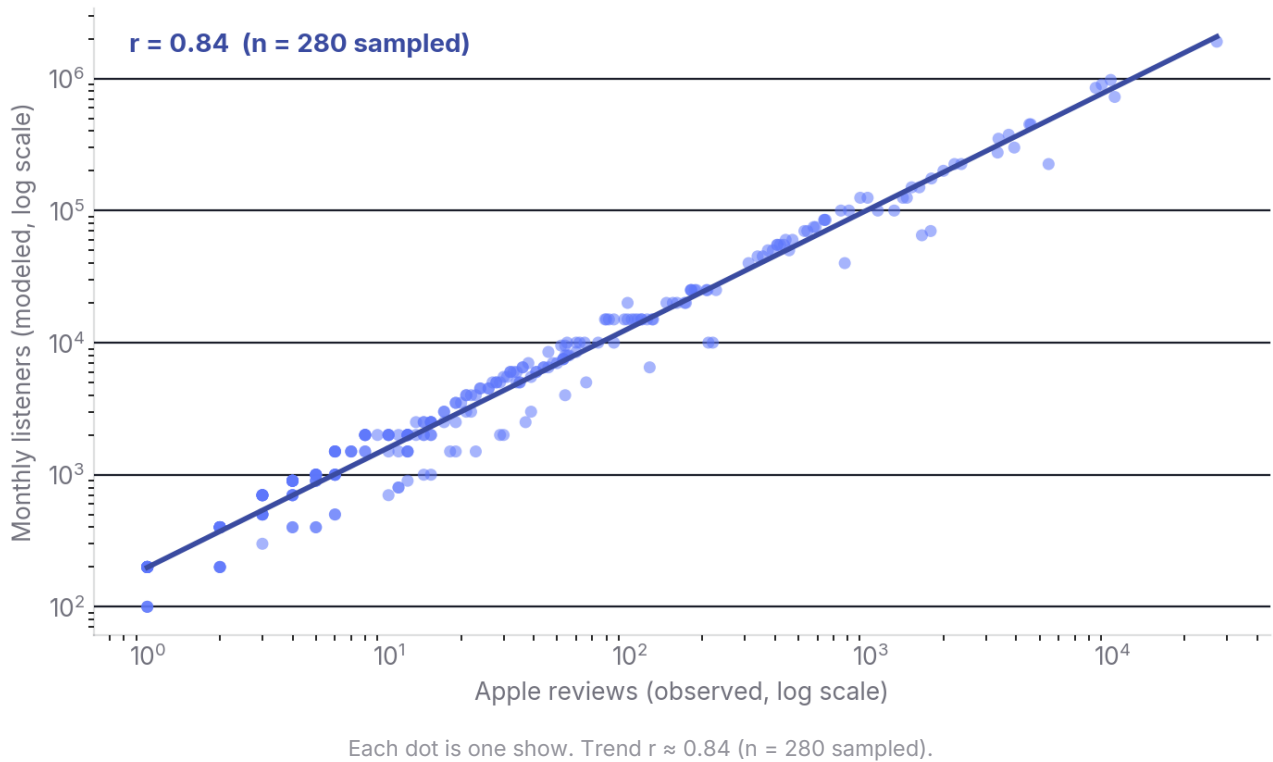
As a consequence, the correlation between Apple rating and monthly listeners is essentially zero ($r = -0.06$). A 4.9-star podcast is not measurably more popular than a 4.5-star one.

The relationship between review count and listener volume, by contrast, is extraordinary, $r \approx 0.84$, a very strong relationship.

In plain English: how many people care enough to review a show is essentially a one-to-one proxy for how many people listen to it. Reviews do not drive listeners. They reflect them.

FIGURE 04.2 · CORRELATION

Reviews (observed) vs monthly listeners (modeled), log scale



85.4%: the share of total monthly listening hours captured by the top 10% of shows. The next 40% take roughly 13% of the audience. The bottom half, some 17,000 podcasts, share what is left, around 1% of all listening.

/05 · CONTENT PATTERNS

Most shows are short. The biggest shows are long.

What creators produce and what audiences reward are two different distributions, and the gap between them is one of the most actionable findings in the dataset.

WHAT CREATORS PRODUCE

41 min

A typical episode is about 41 minutes long. Roughly two out of three podcasts publish episodes between 20 and 60 minutes: long enough to develop an idea, short enough to fit a commute or a workout.

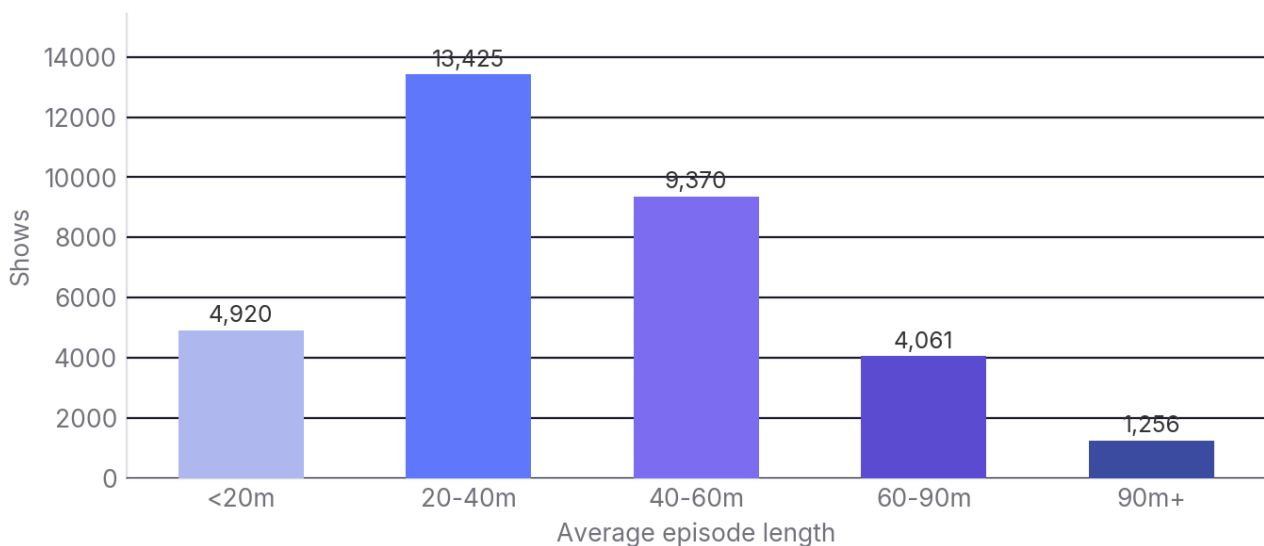
WHAT AUDIENCES REWARD

+225%

Episodes 90 minutes or longer have a typical reach roughly 225% higher than shows in the popular 20–40 minute range. The long-form bucket is small, but its shows tend to reach much larger audiences.

FIGURE 05.1

Episode length, how many shows in each range



The 20–40 minute bucket is the most crowded, holding ~41% of shows with length data.

HOW TO READ THE CHARTS IN THIS SECTION

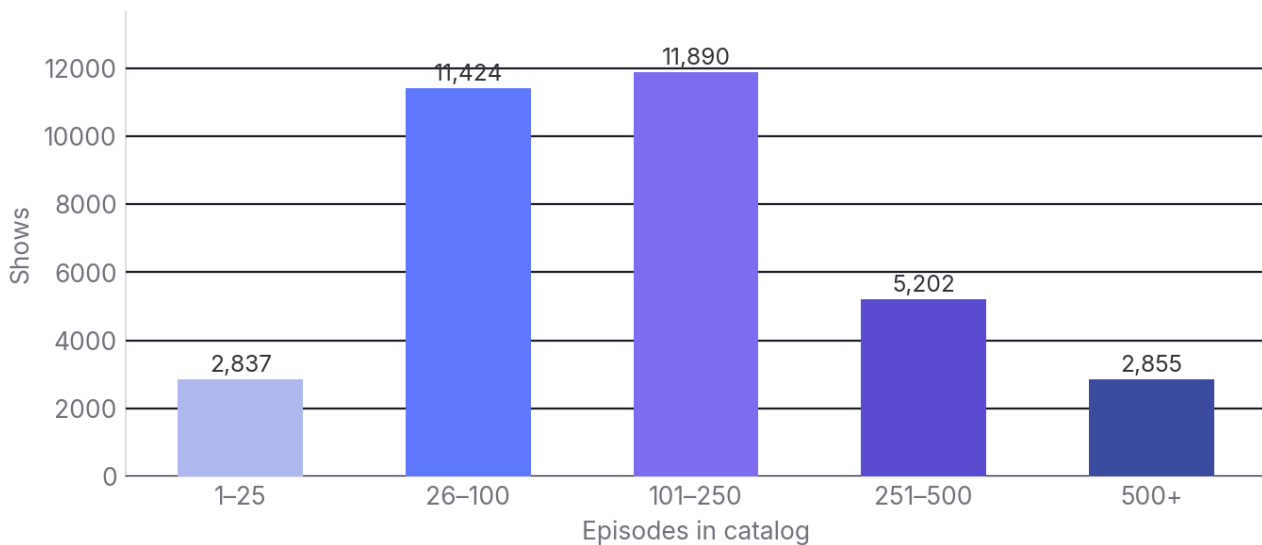
The bars in both figures show the number of shows in each bucket. The audience commentary that follows is based on median listener count within each bucket, a separate calculation, not the bar heights.

There are two findings in this section, and they do not agree with each other, which is exactly why both matter. The first is what creators actually produce: most shows are 20–60 minutes long, and most of them have somewhere between 100 and 500 episodes in their catalog. That is the working pattern of the average video podcast.

The second finding is what audiences actually reward. If we measure the median monthly listenership within each bucket, the picture flips. Short shows (under 20 minutes) median around **1K monthly listeners**. Long shows (90+ minutes) median closer to **6.5K**, about 6.5× the reach of short shows. Length and audience size are associated; we cannot say from this dataset that one causes the other.

FIGURE 05.2

Catalog size, how many episodes shows have published



Most shows sit at 100–500 episodes; only 8% ever cross the 500-mark.

A note on sample size: the long-form bucket is small, only about 1,256 shows publish 90+ minute episodes, but the median calculation is robust within it, and the gap relative to the popular 20–40 minute bucket is consistent. The signal is real even though the cohort is narrow. (A further 1,176 shows are excluded from the length buckets entirely because their average episode length could not be parsed; the five buckets shown sum to 33,032, not 34,208.)

Catalog depth tells a parallel story. Shows under 25 episodes sit at a typical reach of **200 monthly listeners**. Shows past 500 episodes reach **30K**, a 150× difference. The most plausible read is not that "more episodes equals success"; it is that consistency over time compounds. A show that has reached 500 episodes has typically been publishing on a stable cadence for several years, long enough for word-of-mouth, search visibility, and audience habit to accumulate.

The takeaway is simple. The popular format is not the highest-reaching format. Most creators settle into 30–40 minute episodes and stop somewhere around 250. The shows that break out of the long tail tend to look different: they run longer per episode, and they keep publishing for longer overall.

A directional read, consistent with broader industry observations: long-form video podcasts behave more like television than radio. Audiences who commit to a 90-minute show are committing to a relationship, and platforms reward sustained watch-time. We cannot validate that mechanism directly from this dataset, but the listener distribution is consistent with it.

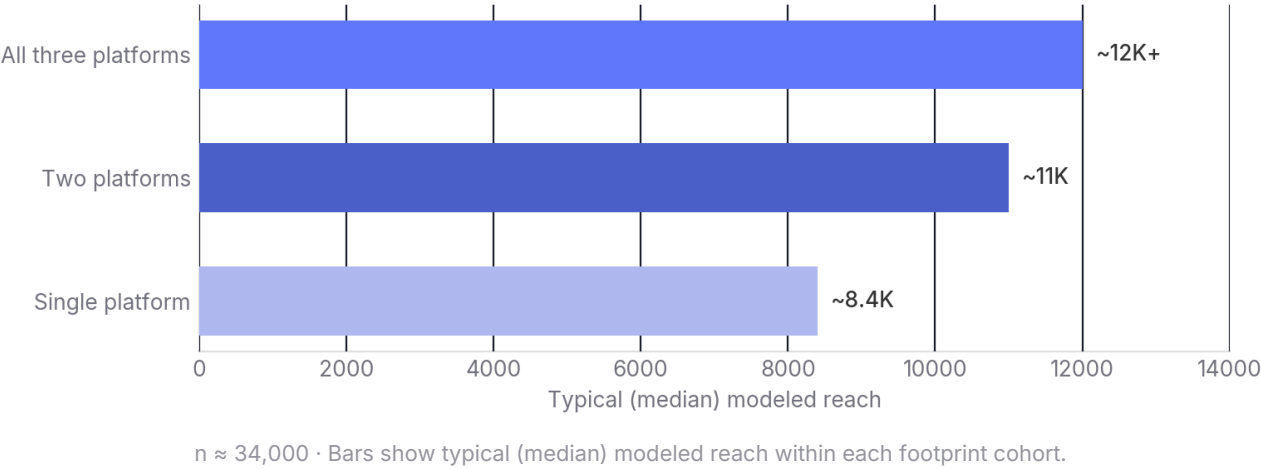
/05 · PLATFORM PRESENCE

The triple-stack is the standard.

Apple, Spotify, and YouTube are no longer alternatives, they are a single connected distribution layer. 89.8% of video podcasts publish on all three. Among the Top 10, that figure is 100%. Among the Top 100, it is 98%. Triple-presence is the working definition of a serious show.

APPLE PODCASTS 98.9% 33,844 of 34,208 shows. The default RSS layer of the industry.	SPOTIFY 92.5% 31,630 of 34,208 shows. Spotify-only is essentially extinct; everyone here uses it as a discovery channel.
YOUTUBE 97.8% 33,464 of 34,208 shows. The video layer where these podcasts now live their cultural life.	THE TRIPLE STACK 89.8% 30,702 of 34,208 shows publish on Apple and Spotify and YouTube simultaneously. Another 7.7% cover two of the three; single-platform shows are statistically negligible at 0.3%.

FIGURE 05.3
Audience scale (modeled) by number of platforms covered



The pattern in the chart above is monotonic: each additional platform a show occupies lifts its typical modeled reach, from roughly 8,400 listeners on a single platform to about 11,000 on two and past 12,000 on all three. The climb is gentle at the median but turns decisive at the top of the distribution, where almost every audience leader runs the full stack. The three subsections that follow read that pattern from three angles: the cost of skipping a platform, the combinations creators actually choose, and which platform tends to be the one left out.

Each platform you skip costs you reach

The audience curve scales smoothly with platform count. Shows on all three platforms reach a typical audience of **~12K+ monthly listeners**. Drop one platform and the typical reach falls to ~11,000. Drop two and it drops further to ~8,400. The penalty is not dramatic at the median, but at the top of the distribution it becomes overwhelming.

A show on all three platforms is **2.8×** more likely to land in the top decile of audience size than a single-platform show. Every one of the Top 10, and 98 of the Top 100, covers all three. The few exceptions are network shows whose business model intentionally restricts distribution.

The triple-stack is not a growth strategy, it is the entry ticket. Skipping a platform does not fail you; it caps you.

The seven combinations, what creators actually choose

Across approximately 34,000 video podcasts, only seven of the eight possible platform combinations actually exist (no show is on none of them). The distribution is dramatically lopsided: one combination, the full triple stack, claims roughly nine in ten shows, and the long tail of unusual choices barely registers.

The strategic read for any new video-first show is unambiguous: budget for triple distribution from day one. Treat YouTube as your video home, Apple as the audio default, and Spotify as the discovery surface. Each platform you skip does not just shrink your potential audience, it removes you from a distribution layer that the audience-leaders consider non-negotiable.

When a stack is incomplete, the missing piece is usually Spotify

The per-platform coverage figures make the shape of the gap easy to read. Apple sits at 98.9% coverage and YouTube at 97.8%, so when a show runs only part of the stack, those two are almost never the pieces that are absent. Spotify, at 92.5%, is the platform most often left out, which makes the most common partial stack an Apple-plus-YouTube show that has simply never set up Spotify distribution.

That pattern says something about how these catalogs are built. Apple presence comes nearly free with an RSS feed, and a video-first show starts on YouTube by definition, so both fill in by default. Spotify is the step that requires a deliberate submission, and a slice of the catalog never takes it. For those shows it is also the cheapest fix on the board: completing the stack is an afternoon of setup, not a production change, and it moves a show into the platform footprint that nearly every audience leader in this dataset already occupies.

Net: triple-stack distribution is table stakes, and Spotify is the gap most often left open. For the minority of shows still missing a platform, closing it is the lowest-effort, highest-certainty distribution move available, and it is almost always Spotify.

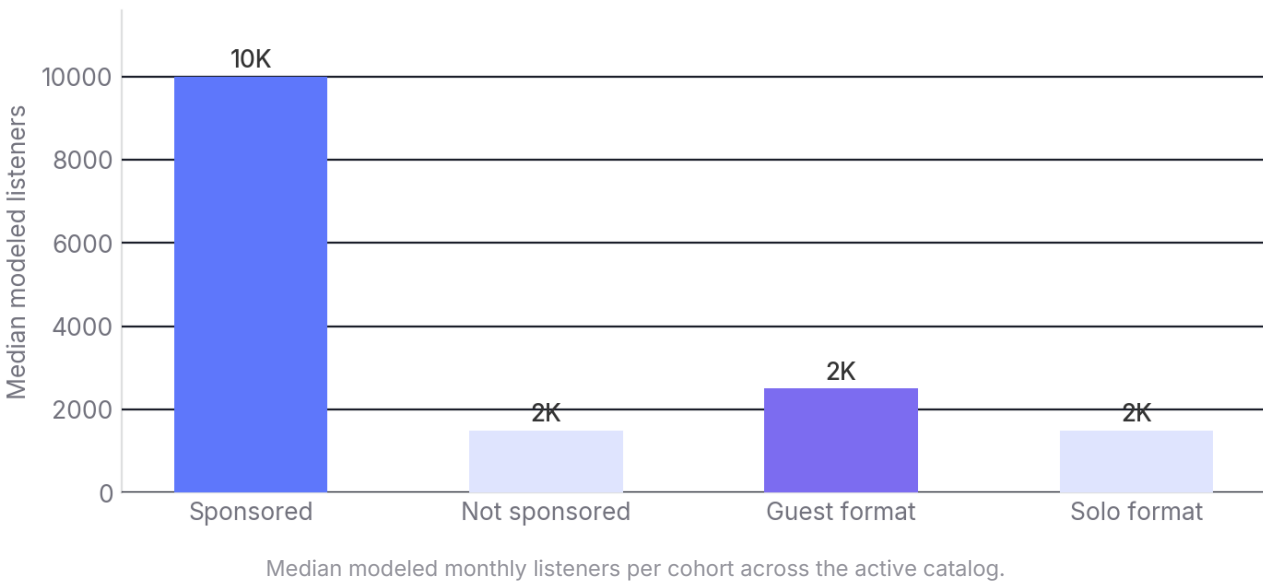
/06 · MONETIZATION & FORMAT

Sponsors follow scale, not stars.

Only about one in four English-language video shows runs sponsorships, but those that do are systematically larger, not better-rated, than those that do not.

WITH SPONSORS 22.9% Show evidence of brand activity (about 7,800 podcasts). Of these, ~6,300 have detailed sponsor records; per-show sponsor counts cited below are based on this 18.4% subset.	WITH GUESTS 71.8% Run regular interview or conversation formats.
ON A NETWORK 4.3% Affiliated with a podcast network. The catalog is overwhelmingly independent.	SPONSOR LISTENER LIFT +567% Sponsored shows out-reach non-sponsored ones by roughly 7x at the median.

FIGURE 06.1
Median modeled listeners, sponsorship and format compared



Sponsored or solo, guest or no

A sponsored show pulls in a median of **10,000 monthly listeners**, versus just 1,500 for non-sponsored peers, roughly seven times more. The simplest way to read this: brands rarely pick small shows. Almost all of the sponsorship inventory in this catalog is concentrated in the small fraction of shows that have already built audiences large enough to be commercially interesting.

Guest-driven shows reach a median of **2,500 listeners** versus 1,500 for solo formats, about 67% higher. The gap is real but modest in absolute terms; the bigger differentiator is the top of the market, where 10 of the top 10 shows are guest-format. Conversation and interview formats dominate at the high end even if they do not transform a small show.

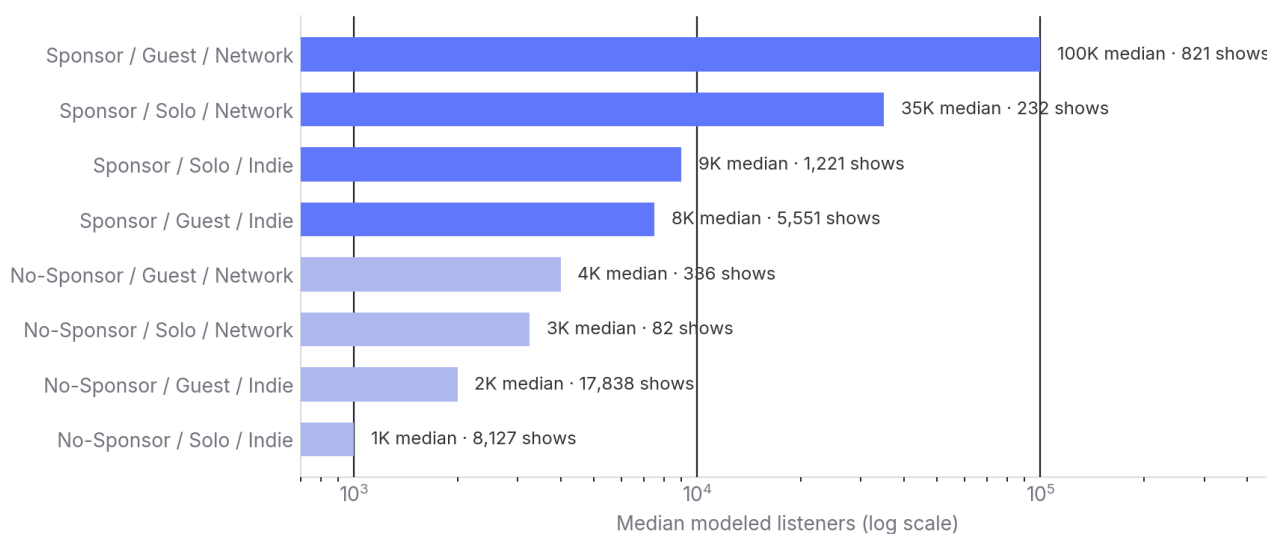
Sponsorship is best understood as a consequence of audience size, not a cause of it. Brands underwrite shows that already have listeners.

Format combinations, the eight playbooks, sized by audience

There are eight production-strategy combinations a video podcast can run: sponsored or not × guest or solo × network or independent. Each has a different median audience. The matrix combines three independent strategic choices into the eight unique combinations a video show can occupy.

FIGURE 06.2

Median modeled listeners by strategy combination



Blue bars: sponsored combinations. Light bars: non-sponsored. Annotations show the median and the number of shows running each exact combination.

The top of the matrix is unambiguous: the 821 shows that combine sponsorship, guests, and a network affiliation post a median of 100,000 monthly listeners, two full orders of magnitude above the 8,127 independent, solo, unsponsored shows at the bottom (median 1,000). In between, every added strategic layer is associated with a higher median. The two largest cohorts by count, independent guest shows without sponsorship (17,838 shows) and independent solo shows without sponsorship (8,127), are also the two smallest by audience.

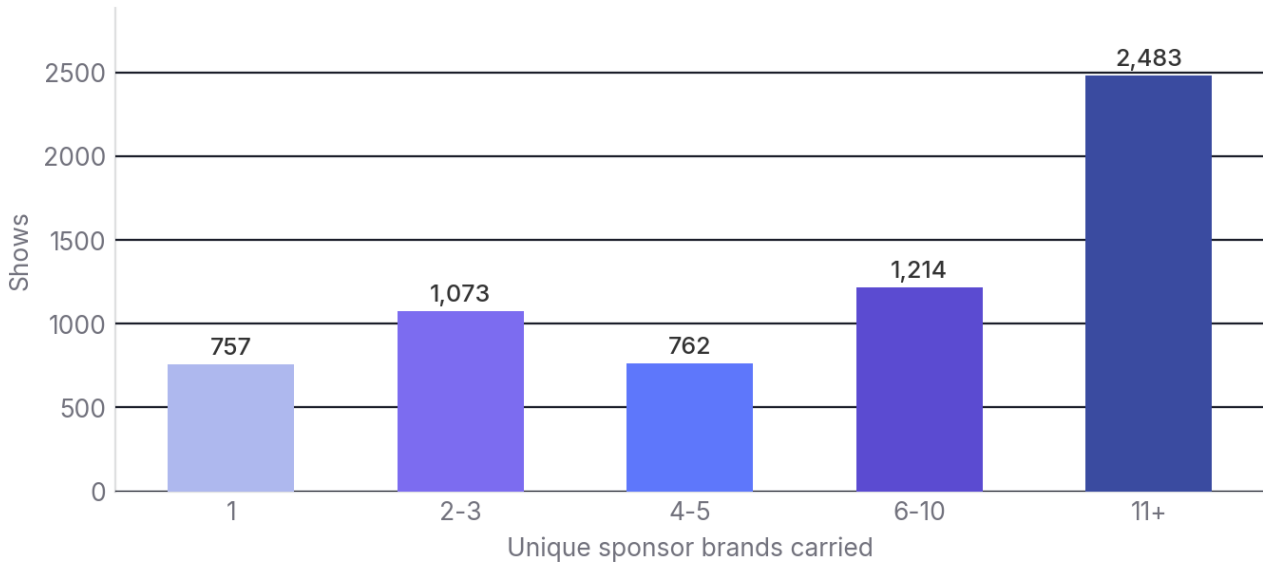
How sponsorship works at scale

About **23%** of all podcasts in the catalog (around 7,800 shows) carry confirmed sponsorships. For roughly 6,300 of these, we also have the names of the specific sponsor brands; the rest are confirmed sponsored but the brand list is not available, so brand-level analysis below is restricted to the shows where the data is complete.

Among shows where we can count sponsor brands, the typical sponsored show carries **7 different brands** in the period observed. The mean is much higher (around 15) because a small number of large network productions run 50, 100, or even hundreds of brands across their archive, pulling the average upward.

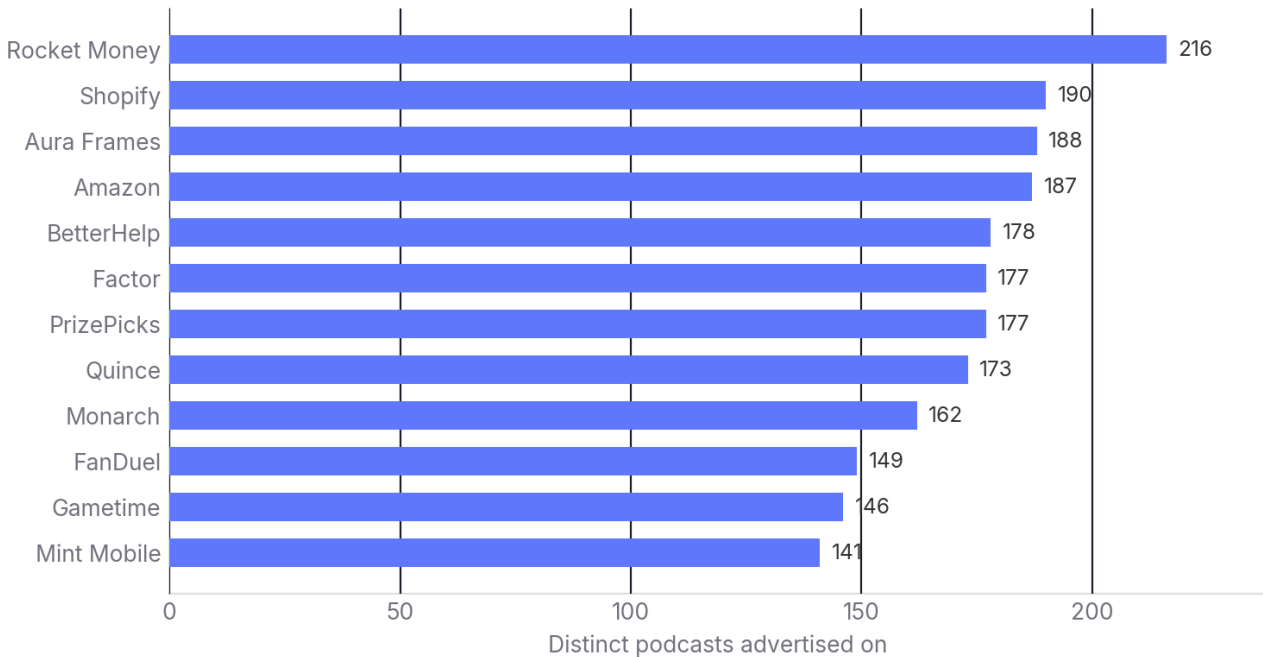
Sponsor density tracks listener size closely. Shows with no sponsors median around 2,000 listeners; shows running 11 or more brands median around 10,000, roughly five times higher. The pattern reads cleanly: brands underwrite shows that already have audiences, not the other way around.

FIGURE 06.3
Sponsor count distribution, how many shows carry how many brands



Bars show the number of shows in each bracket (only shows with detailed sponsor data are included).

FIGURE 06.4
Most-frequent sponsors across the catalog



Top 12 brands ranked by the number of distinct podcasts they advertise on.

Which audiences attract the most sponsors

A simple way to read this: take all the podcasts in the catalog and split them by their typical listener, mostly female listeners, mostly male listeners, or a roughly even mix. Then ask, how often do brands actually sponsor each type of show? The answer is clear and consistent: shows with a clearly identifiable audience, whether male-skewed or female-skewed, get sponsored more often than shows with a mixed audience. Sponsors prefer to know exactly who they are reaching.

#1 MOST SPONSORED Male-leaning audience Shows in this group: 15,233 Carry sponsors: 28.1% Typical brand count when sponsored: 7 brands Most common in sports, business, finance, technology, and politics. The single largest audience-type segment in the catalog.	#2 MOST SPONSORED Female-leaning audience Shows in this group: 7,716 Carry sponsors: 20.8% Typical brand count when sponsored: 9 brands Common in true crime, wellness, lifestyle, and parenting. When sponsored, these shows often carry more brands per episode than male-leaning ones.	LEAST SPONSORED Balanced audience Shows in this group: 11,248 Carry sponsors: 17.3% Typical brand count when sponsored: 6 brands Common in news, society & culture, and general-interest interview shows. Brands find it harder to target a non-specific audience.
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The pattern is simple: sponsors prefer audiences they can clearly describe. Male-leaning shows are sponsored about 1.6× as often as balanced shows. Female-leaning shows sit just behind, with similar density when they are sponsored.

The income cross-cut shows a similar pattern but is much weaker. High-income-dominant shows carry slightly more sponsor brands on average than medium-income shows, but the gap is small. Most sponsor inventory is bought against medium-income audiences simply because that is where most listeners are; the high-income segment commands a premium per-listener but does not add up to enough volume to dominate sponsor activity.

Brand density is concentrated as well. Among the 6,289 shows with brand-level records, the single largest bucket is 11 or more unique sponsors: 2,483 shows, roughly 40% of the subset. The mean of 14.9 brands sits far above the median of 7 because a small group of shows carries hundreds of distinct advertisers over their run. Once a show demonstrates it can sell and deliver inventory, additional advertisers tend to follow, so density compounds at the top while most sponsored shows stay in the single digits.

The brand roster itself tells a story. The most frequent advertisers in the catalog, led by Rocket Money, Shopify, Aura Frames, Amazon, BetterHelp, Factor, and PrizePicks, are overwhelmingly direct-response and performance brands that measure outcomes through promo codes and affiliate links. Large brand-awareness budgets are comparatively rare in this list, which suggests video podcast inventory in 2026 is still bought primarily as a measurable performance channel rather than as a pure reach medium.

/07 · THE TOP TEN

The shows that move the world.

Ten podcasts. Approximately 55 million combined monthly listeners between them. They share almost no traits with the median show, except, notably, the absolute requirement to be on YouTube.

#	Show	Monthly listeners	Apple reviews	Rating	Network	Format
1	The Joe Rogan Experience Interview / Conversation	14M+	210K+	4.6	Independent	Guest
2	Crime Junkie True Crime	9M+	350K+	4.7	Independent	Guest
3	Call Her Daddy Comedy	5M+	160K+	4.4	SiriusXM Podcasts	Guest
4	The Daily News & Politics	4.5M+	100K+	4.3	The New York Times	Guest
5	Sofia with an F Comedy	4.4M+	80K+	3.8	Independent	Guest
6	VIEWS with David Dobrik & Jason Nash Society & Culture	4.1M+	70K+	4.8	Independent	Guest
7	The Diary Of A CEO with Steven Bartlett Business & Finance	4M+	15K+	4.7	Independent	Guest
8	This American Life Society & Culture	3.5M+	85K+	4.6	Independent	Guest
9	Criminal True Crime	3.4M+	35K+	4.7	Independent	Guest
10	The Shawn Ryan Show Interview / Conversation	3.1M+	40K+	4.9	Cumulus Podcast Network	Guest

Listener and review counts shown as ranges (e.g. "10M+", "250K+"); these reflect modeled estimates and visible review counts at snapshot date.

TOP 10, AVG LISTENERS 5.5M Sum of the top 10 listener counts ÷ 10, roughly 2,750× the dataset median of ~2K.	ON YOUTUBE 10/10 Every single top-10 show distributes on YouTube.
RUN GUESTS 10/10 All 10 of the top podcasts use guest or interview formats; the format dominates the top tier.	NETWORK-BACKED 3/10 Only 3 of the top 10 are formally network-backed; the other 7 operate independently.

Compared with the rest of the dataset, the top 10 are universally guest-driven (10/10 vs 72% across the dataset), universally sponsored (10/10 vs 23%), and universally on YouTube. Their median rating, 4.65, sits below the dataset average of 4.72, further evidence that ratings do not make the audience.

What unites them is something the numbers can hint at but cannot fully explain: each is a personality-led, video-native franchise in the cultural register of a late-night talk program or a true-crime docuseries. They are not "podcasts" in the early-2010s sense. They are media properties.

— /08 · KEY INSIGHTS

Eight findings that change the playbook.

The data tells a story that contradicts most podcast advice circulating in 2026. Here are the eight findings most worth carrying forward.

01 **Reviews predict listeners almost perfectly. Stars do not.**

The correlation between review count and monthly listeners is $r \approx 0.84$, a very strong relationship, though not the near-perfect one earlier reports suggested. The correlation between star rating and listeners is $r \approx -0.06$, statistically zero. Why it happens: highly-rated shows attract their fans, but fans of all popular shows leave reviews at roughly the same rate. So review counts grow with audience, while ratings cap out at the ceiling of "people who liked it." The practical takeaway: when comparing two podcasts you know nothing else about, compare their review counts, not their stars.

02 **The top 10% of shows hold 85% of all listening.**

Roughly half of all monthly listening hours flow to the top ~1,500 podcasts; the bottom 17,000 share around 1% of what is left. Why it happens: attention is a winner-take-most market. Once a show crosses a threshold of cultural visibility, usually around 100,000 monthly listeners, algorithmic recommendations, social mentions, and word-of-mouth all compound. Shows below that threshold rarely break out without a dedicated marketing push or a host who is already famous from somewhere else.

03 **Every top-10 show is on YouTube. Few non-YouTube shows scale.**

A 100% YouTube presence in the top 10 is not a coincidence. Why it happens: in 2026, video clipping, YouTube Shorts, Reels, TikTok, is the dominant podcast discovery mechanism. A show that does not film cannot supply the clips, cannot be embedded in a thumbnail-driven feed, and cannot be discovered by anyone who is not already searching for podcasts. For a video podcast, audio-only distribution is now a structural disadvantage.

04 **A clear audience lean out-listens a balanced one.**

The data block does not contain median-listener figures broken out by host gender configuration (only counts), so we do not quote a specific median premium here. Where the data does let us measure audience size by composition, the clear pattern is in the audience-skew cut (section /03): shows with a clear audience lean, either male or female, reach a median of 2.5K monthly listeners, while balanced-audience shows trail at 1.5K. Why it might happen: a clearly-defined community is easier to grow than an undifferentiated one.

05 **Endurance is rewarded; quitting is the dominant failure mode.**

Shows under 25 episodes have a median of 200 monthly listeners. Shows past 500 episodes have a median of 30,000, a 150× difference. Why it happens: back catalogs become discoverable assets. After year three, a show is being found through old episodes, search, and recommendation as much as through new releases. Most podcasts never reach that point: the typical show in our dataset has a median of 125 episodes total (mean: ~225, pulled higher by long-running franchises). For most creators, sustaining publishing past 250 episodes is the harder, less-glamorous half of the work that actually compounds audience.

0 Long-form wins the long game.

6 Episodes of 90 minutes or longer post the highest median listenership of every length bucket, roughly 6.5× the reach of sub-20-minute formats. Why it happens: long-form video has become the prestige format on YouTube, with watchtime weighted heavily by the algorithm. A 90-minute interview generates roughly 4× the watchtime per session of a 22-minute commute show, and watchtime is what the recommendation system optimizes. For audio-first listeners, longer episodes also carry a "habit" advantage: weekly long-form replaces a TV show, where short-form competes with social media for attention.

0 Sponsorship reflects audience size, not the other way around.

7 Sponsored shows reach ~7× more median listeners than non-sponsored ones (10K vs 1.5K, a +567% lift), but their average ratings are identical. Why it happens: brands underwrite scale, not quality. A small show with a 4.9 rating and 5,000 listeners is far less likely to attract sponsors than a mid-tier show with a 4.4 rating and 50,000 listeners. The widely-shared advice that "you need a tight pitch deck to win sponsors" is mostly downstream of the simpler truth that you need an audience first.

0 The triple-stack is the entry ticket.

8 89.8% of the catalog publishes on Apple, Spotify, and YouTube simultaneously, and every one of the Top 10 covers all three. A show on all three platforms is 2.8× more likely to land in the top decile of audience size than a single-platform show. Why it happens: each platform is now a distinct discovery surface, and the audience-leaders treat full coverage as non-negotiable. Skipping a platform does not fail a show; it caps it.

What the eight findings share

Read together, the eight findings point at the same small set of levers. The forces that actually move audience are structural, distribution on every surface, a long and consistently published catalog, a clearly defined audience, and the long-form watch-time that YouTube rewards. The signals most creators optimise for, star ratings and polished sponsor decks, turn out to be downstream of scale rather than causes of it. Reviews look like a quality metric but function as a popularity one; sponsorship looks like validation but simply tracks audience size.

The encouraging implication is that none of the real levers depend on luck or a viral moment. Publishing on all three platforms, booking guests, running longer episodes, and staying on a weekly cadence are all deliberate choices available to any show. The hard part is not knowing what to do; it is doing it for the years it takes the catalog to compound.

The through-line: scale in video podcasting is engineered, not stumbled into. Distribution breadth and publishing endurance explain far more of who wins than production polish or rating quality ever do.

 /09 · TRY IT

Score your podcast against the Top-10 playbook.

The data identifies a handful of strategic choices that consistently separate top-decile shows from the rest of the catalog. Check the choices you are making (or considering) and tally your score against the Top-10 traits. Maximum score: 100. The interactive version lives in the web report.

Podcast Growth Scorecard

Each choice maps to an evidence-backed trait of high-audience video podcasts in our dataset. The point weights reflect how strongly each trait correlates with listener volume in the Top-10 cohort.

Strategic choice	Evidence	Points
My show publishes on YouTube	Definitional: 100% of Top 10 are on YouTube.	+20 pts
I also publish on Apple and Spotify	Triple-presence reaches 1.24× the median audience of single-audio shows.	+15 pts
My show runs guest / interview formats	10 of the Top 10 are guest-driven; the format dominates the high end of the market.	+15 pts
My typical episode runs 60+ minutes	90m+ shows median ~6.5K listeners vs. ~1K for sub-20m formats.	+15 pts
I have 250+ episodes in the catalog	500+ episode shows median 23K+ listeners, 4.4× under-25 shows.	+15 pts
I publish on a weekly (or more frequent) cadence	Consistent weekly publishing maps strongly onto top-decile shows.	+10 pts
My show has at least one paid sponsor	Sponsorship correlates with audience size (effect, not cause).	+5 pts
My show has 1,000+ Apple reviews	Review count is a strong proxy for listenership ($r \approx 0.84$).	+5 pts

DISCLAIMER

The scorecard is a directional self-assessment, not a forecast. It reflects associations observed in this dataset between strategic choices and audience volume; it does not predict the size or growth rate of any individual show. Several Top-10 podcasts succeed despite missing one or two of these traits, and many shows that tick every box remain in the long tail. Strategy and execution still matter most.

How to read your total: 80 to 100 points means your strategic configuration matches the choices the top-decile shows make almost trait for trait. 50 to 75 points is the most common range for established independent shows; the table shows which levers remain. Below 50 points usually indicates a show that is early in its run or deliberately optimised for something other than audience scale, and the highest-value next steps are the distribution rows at the top of the table.

— /10 · CONCLUSION

The market has matured.

2026's video podcast ecosystem is no longer a creator frontier. It is a settled media format with established economics, a clear distribution stack, and a textbook power-law audience curve.

For most of the past decade, "the future of podcasting" has been treated as an open question. The data in this report suggests it is largely a closed one. Multi-platform distribution, Apple, Spotify, and YouTube together, is now the floor, not the ceiling. Long-form, video-native, guest-driven content dominates the top of the market. Sponsorship arrives after audience, not before it. Reviews are a mirror; ratings are noise; production format is the strongest predictor of scale.

What is striking is how little of this matches the advice that circulated five years ago. Short, snackable episodes were sold as the format of the future; they are not. Audio purity was supposed to be a moat; it is not. Independent creators were supposed to displace networks; the picture is mixed. Only 3 of the top 10 shows in this report are formally network-backed (Call Her Daddy / SiriusXM, The Daily / The New York Times, Shawn Ryan / Cumulus), while the remaining seven operate as independent productions or under the host's own banner. The ecosystem has converged on a media-company logic regardless of who owns the show: ship long-form video on every platform, build a personality-led franchise, and earn the audience over hundreds of episodes.

The outlook

Three trends are likely to define the next 24 months.

- 1. Consolidation continues.** The top 1% already commands roughly 42% of listening, and infrastructure (networks, ad-tech, AI editing tools) keeps lowering the floor for major franchises while raising the ceiling. Expect the top 10 to absorb still more share.
- 2. The middle gets squeezed.** Shows in the 10K–100K listener band sit in an awkward zone: too big to operate as hobbies, too small to attract major brand budgets. The next wave of consolidation will likely come from networks acquiring or signing this middle.
- 3. Format experimentation moves to the long tail.** Innovative formats, AI co-hosts, real-time call-in shows, interactive video podcasts, will not appear at the top, where risk aversion is highest. They will emerge from the long tail, where thousands of shows are competing for differentiation.

Strategic implications

For creators: prioritize endurance over ambition, video over audio, distribution over polish. Most podcasts that fail simply stopped publishing.

For brands and advertisers: review counts are a more reliable audience proxy than star ratings. Negotiate against reviews per dollar, not stars.

For networks and platforms: the middle of the market is the strategic prize, not the top. The top is already locked.

For analysts and researchers: a podcast is now a multi-platform media object, not an audio file. Single-platform analysis materially understates audience.

/11 · METHODOLOGY

How this report was built.

Every figure in this document is derived from a large-scale podcast intelligence database covering thousands of English-language video shows and millions of underlying signals. The notes below describe the analytical framework without exposing the raw underlying mechanics.

/01 What counts as a podcast

For the purposes of this report, a podcast is defined as a unique show with a stable identity across distribution platforms. Multiple host listings, contributor entries, or distribution endpoints belonging to the same show are consolidated into a single show-level record before analysis begins. All audience, performance, and content metrics are reported at the show level, not at the level of individual contributors, episodes, or platform listings. This is intended to prevent the inflation of any one show's footprint and to make comparisons across the dataset meaningful.

/02 Video podcast definition

"Video podcast" in this report refers to any show whose intelligence record includes confirmed distribution on a major video platform (most commonly YouTube), in addition to its audio distribution. This is a definition of distribution format, not of audience. A show that publishes a video version on YouTube is included even if the majority of its audience consumes the audio feed on Apple or Spotify. Catalog scope: this edition covers approximately 34,000 active English-language video podcasts, restricted to shows that have published at least one new episode within the last twelve months. Dormant shows are excluded from every chart, percentage, and cohort comparison.

/03 Guest format classification

A show is classified as a "guest format" when intelligence signals indicate that it regularly features guest conversations as a core editorial format. This is a judgment about the show's overall tendency, not a guarantee that every episode includes a guest. Solo monologue shows, scripted narrative shows, and panel shows with stable cast rotations are not classified as guest formats, even if they occasionally feature outside contributors.

/04 Sponsorship classification

A show is classified as having sponsorship when there is evidence of brand partnership or advertising activity associated with it, including ad-read transcripts, sponsor mentions, network ad-deal participation, or platform-side advertising data. This indicates the presence of sponsorship at some point in the show's run. It does not imply continuous monetization, current ad rates, or revenue figures, none of which are reported in this analysis.

/05 How listener estimates are derived

Monthly listener figures presented in this report are modeled estimates, not directly reported audience numbers. They are derived from a combination of observable signals, including audience engagement (such as review activity), publishing consistency over recent periods, and the overall depth of a podcast's content library. Podcasts that demonstrate stronger engagement, release episodes more consistently, and have a larger catalog of content are generally modeled to have a broader listener base. These figures should be interpreted as directional indicators of relative audience scale, designed for benchmarking and trend analysis rather than precise measurement. Differences across broad audience tiers are meaningful, while small differences between similarly sized podcasts should not be over-interpreted.

/06 Data preparation and normalization

Before analysis, the underlying records are consolidated so that each podcast appears exactly once. Performance metrics are standardized to prevent double-counting that can occur when a single show has multiple listings. Missing or incomplete fields are handled with consistent normalization logic, and extreme outliers are controlled using percentile-based caps where they would otherwise distort group averages. Where this report cites averages, both the mean and the median are typically reported when they diverge meaningfully, a divergence common in highly skewed audience distributions like podcasting.

/07 Limitations

Language scope: the dataset is restricted to English-language podcasts; country-level breakdowns reflect English-language production only. Modeled audience data: listener figures are estimates, not directly reported counts; comparisons should be treated as relative rather than absolute. Coverage gaps: some shows may have incomplete network or platform metadata; where coverage is partial, the analysis explicitly excludes missing values rather than imputing them. Network affiliation undercount: network affiliation is detected from public network branding signals; some major networks (e.g., Wondery, NPR, BBC, PRX, Pushkin, SiriusXM) may be undercounted, so the headline figure of ~4.3% network-affiliated should be read as a floor, not a ceiling. Show-level granularity: episode-level performance and segment-level engagement are not part of this report. Temporal scope: the dataset is a snapshot; findings describe the present moment, not a prediction.

/08 Data freshness

This report reflects a snapshot of the English-language video podcast ecosystem as of late April 2026 (snapshot date: 28 April 2026). Audience figures, platform footprints, sponsorship status, and ratings evolve continuously. The findings here describe stable structural patterns that are unlikely to change month-to-month, but specific numbers will drift over time. Where decisions depend on current values (for example, whether a specific show currently runs sponsorships), readers should verify against live sources before acting.

/09 Interpretation note

The findings in this report are analytical and directional. They are designed to identify patterns, surface non-obvious relationships, and inform strategic thinking about the podcast ecosystem. They are not intended as exact measurement of the entire podcast industry, nor as audited audience figures for any individual show. Used appropriately, this kind of intelligence is best treated as a lens for asking sharper questions rather than as a definitive ledger of who is listening to what.

/10 How podcasts were deduplicated to "unique shows"

Many podcasts appear multiple times in raw feeds, through re-uploads, regional editions, host-side and network-side listings, RSS migrations, or platform-specific re-syndication. The deduplication rule works in two passes: each show is first matched on its Feed ID, which uniquely identifies an RSS feed; where Feed ID is missing or ambiguous, the analysis falls back to title-based matching with light normalisation. The most-recent metadata wins per field, except for listener and review counts where the maximum observed value is taken. This is why the report describes a universe of approx. 34,000 unique English-language video podcasts rather than the 55,859 raw rows in the underlying intelligence feed. Critically, listener counts are never summed across rows for the same podcast.

/11 How the Top 10 was selected

The Top 10 ranking is determined strictly by modeled monthly listenership at the snapshot date. It is not a measure of historical reach, lifetime downloads, awards won, cultural footprint, critical reception, or revenue. A show that was massive in 2022 but has lost audience since will not appear, while a show that has only recently crossed the multi-million-listener threshold will. Readers comparing this list to other industry rankings should expect divergences: different reports rank by different signals, and each method produces a slightly different top ten. The ranking here is consistent within itself: every show in the Top 10 is ranked by the same modeled-listener number used everywhere else in the report.

/12 What is outside the scope of this report

Video-only YouTube channels that do not ship a paired audio feed. Private or internal corporate podcasts, and shows distributed only behind paywalls or login walls. Non-English shows. Podcasts under approximately 500 monthly listeners, which fall beneath most platform discovery surfaces and cannot be reliably modeled. Revenue, advertising rates, and sponsor dollar values: the report classifies whether a show runs sponsorships as a binary indicator; it does not estimate how much money any show earns. Listener-side location data: the country and region fields describe where the show is produced, not where its listeners live.

/13 How demographic estimates are derived

Audience composition figures (gender split, income tier, generational mix) are modeled estimates, not directly reported survey data. They are calibrated for each show using content classification, host attributes, audience review patterns, social-platform follower composition, and category-level priors. Dataset-wide demographic figures are calculated as listener-weighted averages: each show's percentages are weighted by its modeled monthly listener count before aggregation. Important limitation, classifier concentration: when asking which cohort dominates each show, the classifier tends to default to the modal cohort. Medium income comes back as the dominant tier for roughly 96% of shows, and Millennials as the dominant generation for roughly 82%. Read the dominant-tier counts as directional; the listener-weighted percentages cited in the headline cards (Medium income share = 59%, Millennial share = 49%) are more reliable because they preserve the underlying mix.

/14 How sponsor data is captured

Two sponsor fields are used: a binary sponsorship indicator and a unique sponsor count. The sponsor count reflects unique sponsor brands, not the number of ad reads or campaign cycles. A show running the same advertiser across 30 episodes is counted as one sponsor; a show with three different advertisers in a single episode is counted as three. The "Top Sponsors" ranking counts the number of distinct shows each brand appears on. Two coverage tiers: roughly 22.9% of shows (about 7,800 podcasts) carry confirmed sponsorship activity according to the binary indicator; of these, only ~6,300 (18.4% of the catalog) have detailed brand records. All per-show density statistics are calculated against the 18.4% subset only, and are labelled as such throughout the report.

/15 How listener counts compare to other industry sources

The monthly listener figures are modeled estimates derived from a multi-signal model. They are not measured downloads, and they are not survey-based unique-listener counts. The listener estimates use a tiered model: the engine snaps individual show estimates to common values (1,000; 2,500; 9,000; 35,000; 100,000 and so on) rather than producing a continuous distribution; treat each listener number as a band, not a precise count. Third-party sources may report different absolute figures for top-tier shows: Edison Podcast Metrics uses a survey-based panel that estimates unique monthly listeners and typically reports lower figures for very large shows; Podscribe and similar adtech platforms measure ad-impression delivery and can produce different figures again. For internal comparisons within this report the figures are consistent because they all come from the same model; for external comparisons, expect the absolute numbers to differ even when the relative orderings agree.

Citation and attribution.

If you reference this report in articles, research, presentations, or commentary, the suggested citation formats are below. Direct citations and links back to this report are encouraged.

Preferred attribution: "According to MillionPodcasts, a podcast database tracking 2.8 million shows, ..." Or, in body text: "MillionPodcasts data shows that ..." with a hyperlink to <https://www.millionpodcasts.com>.

For the underlying dataset: "Findings from The State of Video Podcasting 2026, a research report from MillionPodcasts based on a catalog of approximately 34,000 active English-language video podcasts."

Suggested source line: Source: MillionPodcasts Research, The State of Video Podcasting, 2026. Snapshot: May 2026.

Excerpts of up to a paragraph may be quoted with attribution; longer sections should be summarized in the citing publication's own words.

A final note on the headline reach figure

The 1.1 billion combined-reach figure that circulates alongside this dataset is the sum of every podcast's individual modeled monthly listenership. It counts listener-show pairs, not unique humans: the same listener is counted across every show they follow, typically five to eight in industry research. The unique global audience behind this figure is in the low hundreds of millions, not a billion-plus. It is the right metric for sizing aggregate engagement across the ecosystem or comparing one show's reach to another's; it is not the right metric for stating the size of the global podcast audience. The same caveat applies to per-category and per-segment subtotals.

METHODOLOGY QUESTIONS

For questions about the methodology, requests for additional data cuts, or clarification on any figure cited in the report, contact: Anuj Agarwal, Founder, MillionPodcasts.

Email: anuj@millionpodcasts.com · Web: <https://www.millionpodcasts.com> · Snapshot date: 28 April 2026

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